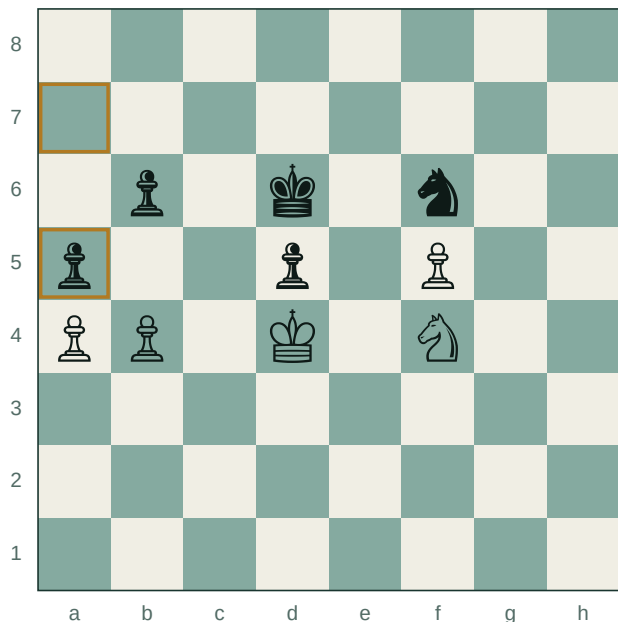


Knight-ending routes: White, move 49

Knight-ending routes

White to move



Previous move: 48...a5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

49. b5 Ne4 50. Nxd5

49.b5 The pawn moves from b4 to b5. Recorded reply: **49...Ne4**.

50.Nxd5 The knight captures the pawn on d5.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A knight changes color with every move and may need a detour. Check the route square by square before trusting a race estimate.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Knight endings reward exact route calculation. Forks can change a pawn race, while a distant passer may outrun the knight's short-range movement.

HOW TO LOOK

Map the knight's checking moves and its route to the critical blockade square. Count moves rather than judging distance by appearance.

The defending king is on d6. Geometrically undefended: knight on f6. Check for tactical protection.